Royal College of Art
Postgraduate Art and Design

Programme Specification

1. General Information

Programme title:	Intelligent Mobility
Award:	Master's
Qualification Framework level:	Level 7
School/Department or equivalent:	School of Communication & Design
Campus location(s):	Battersea
Total UK credits:	180
Date valid from/to:	2026-27

2. Programme Philosophy

The MA Intelligent Mobility programme builds on the rich history of vehicle design at the RCA and places this within the context of a number of emerging social, cultural and technical changes. These include the shift to autonomous systems, renewable power, demographic changes and the increasing synthesis between man and machine. The programme defines and describes a paradigm shift which brings together existing fields with a design-led approach that addresses both physical and virtual aspects of the mobility space as an integrated whole.

The philosophy of this programme is to equip you to deliver critical solutions to holistic mobility needs and issues. The core approach is translating techno-cultural challenge via intense creativity and research - building mature design and innovation propositions to meet new mobility opportunities. You will work closely with mobility design practitioners, thought leaders and leading brands to ensure they have a thorough understanding of industrial practice and the opportunity to engage and influence critical questions relating to business, production and new models of ownership and use.

The aim of this commercial, connected approach is to equip students to be practice leaders within the 'third age' of automotive and mobility design and the broad spectrum of mobility services and artefacts - forming a new generation of designers who have both the skill set and mind-set to operate as strategic leaders with a broad range of abilities and insight about their own 'point-of-impact' on an increasingly diverse industry.

3. Educational Aims and Learning Outcomes of the Programme

Programme aims

- *Aim 1* **Criticality.** The IMMA will equip you to critically respond to the wider concerns of urbanism, social and technology change. You will be required to be informed and contribute to the discourse and debate about mobility - engaging with policy and the political agenda and the evolution of urban living, mobility user experience and the increasing synthesis between man and machine.

- *Aim 2* **Creativity.** IMMA takes an ambitious pluralistic approach which demands you adopt an innovative and visionary approach to the formation of new mobility propositions. IMMA promotes the development of new ideologies as part of the design process to engage with global issues such as sustainability, new technology and emergent business models.

- *Aim 3* **Research**. You will explore mobility in complex and changing worlds using an innovative inter-disciplinary research informed design approach. The IMMA will aim to ensure you build expertise in the knowledge and skills necessary to apply a range of research approaches and methods.

- *Aim 4* **Strategic design.** The IMMA aims to place you at the forefront of the 'third age' of automotive and mobility design. Through its original teaching timetable expert staff and collaboration with industry and users – the programme educates designers to be strategic and visionary. The programme is unique in advancing traditional mobility design into a richer space of user and techno-cultural opportunity – which demands you be knowledgeable of, and consistent with, the standards and expectations of the mobility sector.

Learning Outcomes

Upon successful completion of the programme, you will be expected to meet the requirements of both the College-wide Learning Outcomes and your programme-specific Learning Outcomes.

College-Wide Learning Outcomes

You should be able to:

- Interrogate and articulate the intentions of your work in relation to the critical and conceptual context of your field(s) of study;
- Independently plan and produce work that is informed by developments at the forefront of your field(s) of study;
- Evaluate and critique the principles and methods of research in your field(s) of study, and apply these principles to your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice;
- Demonstrate originality in how you translate knowledge into practice;
- Communicate your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice to a non-specialist audience;
- Critically reflect on the likely public impact of your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice, and on your responsibilities as a practitioner;
- Define your professional ambitions and identify the challenges involved in meeting them.

Programme-Specific Learning Outcomes

You should be able to:

- INNOVATION: Design and develop innovative ideas that create and propose new directions for impactful mobility solutions and propositions;
- CRITICALITY: Critique, position and evaluate your work with regard to the context of the mobility landscape and to enable the production of new knowledge;

- PRODUCTION: Synthesise and produce work at a level of resolution that enables you to discuss and argue its feasibility;
- EXPERIMENTATION: Experiment, explore and evaluate in order to translate ideas into novel mobility solutions;
- IDENTITY: Develop a personal critical and creative identity which enables you to effectively lead the design industry.

4. What Will I Learn?

Curriculum Map

Term 1	Term 2	Term 3
People and Places (15 credits)	Grand Challenge (15 credits)	Independent Research Project (60 credits)
Humanising Technology (30 credits)	Automotive Transitions (30 credits)	
Across RCA (15 credits)	Core Skills (15 credits)	

Programme Structure

Unit Title	Term	Credit Value	Core or Elective?
People and places *(New vehicle typologies (from micro to macro) Mobility infrastructure, architecture, and sustainable placemaking)*	1	15	C
Humanising technology *(Exploring trust, safety, comfort and wellbeing. Developing novel interactions and journey experiences across autonomous, shared & new mobility etc.)*	1	30	C
AcrossRCA (College-Wide Unit)	1	15	C
Core Skills	2	15	C
Grand Challenge *Contemporary design project exploring current key global themes via team delivery*	2	15	C
Automotive transitions *Re-imagining vehicle packaging, architecture, vehicle typologies as part of new mobility services and products*	2	30	C
Individual Research Project *(Self-directed and initiated intelligent mobility design project)*	3	60	C

Term 1: People and places
This unit provides a framework to understand how and where future mobility fits into a changing global landscape and how people and place connect through mobility. The unit aims to sensitise you to the scope and limits of different mobility typologies within the mobility mix and highlights the need for design to meet broader infrastructural and social requirements.

Term 1: Humanising technology
This unit aims to explore how recent transformational mobility technologies such as autonomy and electrification can be interpreted to provide new and desirable human interactions in mobility. You are expected to gain a profound and critical understanding of emerging technologies and their place in future mobility design.

Terms 1: **AcrossRCA**
You will participate in AcrossRCA. This unit aims to support you to meet the challenges of a complex, uncertain and changing world by bringing you together to work collaboratively in cross-programme interdisciplinary teams. In your team you will develop a self-initiated themed project, informed by expertise within and beyond the College. These projects will challenge you to collectively use your intellect and imagination to address key cultural, social, environmental and economic challenges. In doing so, you will develop and reflect on the abilities required to translate knowledge into action and help demonstrate the contribution that the creative arts can make to our understanding and experience of the world.

Term 2: Automotive Transitions
This unit focuses on the future of the automotive typology and asks you to reimagine how technology and social trends will influence future automotive design. The unit provides a deep context into the key elements of future automotive design with an emphasis on advanced manufacturing, contemporary socio-cultural issues and questions related to future business models.

Term 2: Grand Challenge
In term 2 you will participate in the Grand Challenge alongside students within and across the School. The aim of this unit is to connect and challenge all students through the introduction of a 'wicked' design problem that requires a cross-disciplinary approach to problem solving which may involve external international partners. This unit and lecture series has been hugely successful in connecting and disrupting disciplines, people, philosophies and approaches to design thinking whilst providing our student body with very unique networking opportunities.

Term 2: Core Skills
The aim of the Core Skills unit is to support you in advancing your academic and professional skills to aid the development of your personal projects at the RCA and beyond in your professional practice and career.

Term 3: Independent Research Project
This is the final master's project and asks students to identify, develop and address a defined research question which is both socially relevant and technically challenging. The work must be

documented at all stages for public dissemination. This will take the form of a physical and or digital (virtual) exhibition of a selection of the students work during their 3 terms.

You are responsible for the intellectual and technical evolution of this project and for leading the research and development of ideas and insights through different stages of the design process. This includes working out who the stakeholders are, how to research and the development of thinking through different media; notably from 2d to 3d and to an appropriate level of resolution.

The scope of the IRP will be agreed with you, and the support of your tutor and will include the following:

- A clearly articulated research question or problem.
- A defined rationale for the scope of the project including a perspective from the identified global opportunity and the students' personal skills and motivations.
- A plan/methodology for the development of the work.
- A fully resolved vision of the work in appropriate media and a clear evidence path which has all the necessary elements of research to underpin the logic reasoning and creative decisions to narrate the IRP student journey.

There are three Independent Study weeks included in your programme (one per term). During these weeks there will be no scheduled teaching or assessment, and limited access to Technical Services. Self-service will be available for inducted users, and you may independently use computing and technology zones, bench spaces, and the resources store and art shop. These weeks are intended for you to work independently, and technical supervision, fabrication support, or supervision of high-risk activities will not be available.

5. How Will I Learn?

The programme will deploy a range of teaching/learning strategies to build skills at a number of levels during the MA as follows:

Personal tutorials will be used to explore and challenge student's attitudes and knowledge about their work in context between individual students and their tutor.
Group tutorials will be used to debate issues across student cohorts and tutors and to examine ideas at depth.
Group seminars will be used to provide a range of contextual and ideological knowledge to students on the programme.
Group workshops and skills training will be used to build key skills in a range of areas during the programme. Typical examples include; specialist CAD training, research skills workshops, tailored bespoke short skills projects.
Individual interim project presentation and reviews (non-examined) will be used to assess and debate students work during projects - leading to verbal and written feedback being given.
Personally directed study will be encouraged during the programme and will be a focus for the IRP as part of the strategic/ideological goals of the programme. Such study will be guided by tutors

through regular personal and group tutorials as below.

Your studies are divided into three terms and comprise scheduled staff-led time such as lectures, seminars and tutorials, as well as independent learning. Each term consists of 60 credits which equates to 600 study hours. During each week you should, as a full-time student, expect about 40 study hours. This is made up of two components:

- contact hours (approximately 5-10 per week) which involve timetabled interaction with tutors (for example, in seminars, critiques and tutorials), fostering intellectual exchange by way of clarifying concepts, addressing key questions and cultivating critical thinking;
- the time you dedicate to developing your work independently (in addition to the contact hours) by way of self-directed study which can include activities such as making in the workshops, working in the studio, conducting research or preparing for assessment.

The amount of time you spend in self-directed, independent study will normally increase as you progress to the final term, particularly as you focus on the public exhibition or completion of your work. The precise pattern of contact hours will vary by unit, term and mode of study.

6. Assessment and Feedback

Regulations

The programme is subject to the Academic Regulations of the Royal College of Art (*the regulations are subject to annual updates and amendments*).

Unit assessment

There will be summative assessment at the end of each. The format for assessment will be in either viva voce examination or through submission of work assessed independent of the student being present.

The following forms of assessments may be used for each unit:

- 2D graphic presentations, drawings and other 2D media
- 3D models - physical and digital
- Interactive simulated environments
- Working physical samples, prototypes and mock-ups
- Digital media, films, video presentations and virtual reality
- Verbal 'viva voce' style presentations
- Written documents, summaries and other text descriptions and narratives
- Critical forums and discussion – peer-to-peer and peer-to-tutor

Information regarding individual assessments will be included in the Unit Descriptors, available at the beginning of the academic year.

7. What Award Can I Get?

To be awarded an RCA MA degree you need to gain 180 credits at level 7 of the Framework for Higher Education Qualifications (FHEQ). This will involve successfully completing all units.

Exit awards: If you have gained at least 60 credits at Level 7, you may be eligible for the exit award of Postgraduate Certificate. If you have gained at least 120 credits at level 7 of the FHEQ, you may be eligible for the exit award of Postgraduate Diploma.